

"Cricket hasn't changed, our attitude has"

BISHEN SINGH BEDI

FORMER INDIA CAPTAIN

I would like to take you back to a time when India beat New Zealand in a five-day Test match. In those days Indians used to get Rs 50 a day for a Test match. But Indians won the game in four days and the Indian Board deducted Rs 50. That was the incentive of winning the game in four days. My friend Adam Gilchrist and many others are waiting with baited breath for April 18 when IPL opens. The people who are running this IPL, if I may remind you all, are using a very well tested formula—OPI and OPM. Other People's Intelligence and Other People's Money.

In the process, some cricketers deservingly will become multi-millionaires, others not so deservingly. Ishant Sharma has been offered millions after bowling not even 100 overs in Australia. I am not debating his promise, but it has to be realised. They say cricket has changed a lot since we played. I wouldn't buy that idea at all—the width of the stumps, the length of the pitch, the weight of the ball is still the same. What has changed is the attitude. The players, the actors,

Chairperson Sharda Ugra with Gilchrist and Bedi



HEMANT CHAWLA

the directors, and the producers, they have changed.

This brings me to a governing body called ICC. It is toothless to the core. My biggest complaint against ICC is that they have done absolutely nothing about the business of chucking. In Indian cricket last season, about 17 chuckers were identified and pointed out for reformatory actions to BCCI. But BCCI or ICC are not reformatory bodies, they are governing bodies, their job is to govern the game, not to reform it. I don't see any reason why an umpire cannot call a chuck, a chuck. There was a time when England and Australia enjoyed the veto power and I would like to think honestly that cricket was much better organised than it is now.

D I S C U S S I O N

Q. There has recently been an acrimonious series between India and Australia, probably the angriest series between the two. Where does the game go in the future?

Gilchrist: It was hard fought, there were undoubtedly times when it did cross the line. What we have got to do particularly as players, and administrators is to learn from, reflect on the way it went over that line. I don't think the boundaries are broken down and the bridge is broken, the damage is not irreparable, it is fine. As I say in an ironic kind of way, these two teams, now moving forward, have a great deal of respect for each other.

Q. In October, Australia tour India again and everyone is anticipating an ultra-aggressive series again. Should the players just go out and play? Or should there be a statement of peace?

Roebuck: Statements of peace don't last that long but I think if you look at Sreesanth, the way he was in Australia this time, he got along well with his bowling. I think that is a lesson for every one. They have exchanged the blows, they have got the mutual respect now and they should be getting over on with the cricket really.

Q. This is for Bishen Singh Bedi. As an ex-player yourself, what is your observation of the way India has played its cricket recently? Have you seen a change in the way they play on the field or their mental skills in cricket?

Bedi: I think they have played with a lot of self belief that is for sure and the sobering influence of Rahul Dravid, Anil Kumble, Sachin Tendulkar has been very, very positive. Some of the youngsters needed to be tamed at times, they

were getting out of the hands in the name of giving it back. What are we giving back? If Mathew Hayden scored a hundred, the best way to give it back is to score a hundred for India, not by shouting and screaming or showing vulgar signs on the field.

Q. The IPL auction looked like a cattle auction in cricket. The dignity of the game went down. It didn't make sense.

Gilchrist: I wasn't here in India for the auction but I must admit it was an odd feeling. I felt a lot like a cow among the rest of the cattle wondering when you are going to get drawn out and then you find out the price you fetched. Then a little later you found out you have a new home for six weeks. It was unique. I doubt we will see anything like that again. But at the moment, I just think we have got to give IPL some time, let us not cast judgement on it, not be too

pessimistic about it, just yet.

Bedi: I am not too sure if we are giving any thought to the process of human growth in this T20 business. It takes 12 years for the young kid to pass out from school. Why can't we do that in say two or three years? We are in such a massive rush.

Roebuck: I differ on the cattle auction—I think what's behind it is called the market place. It governs the rest of our lives, why we expect the sportsmen to be different.

Q. India have a batting coach, a fielding coach, a bowling coach, do we need a sledging coach?

Gilchrist: More is spoken about sledging than what actually happens. The Harbhajan-Symonds issue was a split second on the field but became two months off the field.

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